questions to the Afghan people. The government had no intention of killing him. The soldiers at the checkpoint could have killed him, but did not'.[11] In a matter of hours, Najibullah had become a 'hated dictator' for Wakil, and Massoud, who was leading the Mujahideen into Kabul, had become his 'esteemed brother'.[12]

Sevan had wanted to save Najibullah from exactly such a fate. The plan was worked out with the Indian leadership's political approval. At about 3.20 AM Najibullah's UN handlers informed Nambiar about Dostum's sudden intransigence, and at 4.35 AM Nambiar promptly reported to the UN compound. He was the first ambassador to meet with Najibullah that morning. Such were the UN and Indian expectations (or miscalculation in hindsight) that they had not thought of a 'plan B', in case the exfiltration plan failed.[13] Still, on being pressed by the UN officers, Nambiar agreed to look into giving Najibullah asylum at the Indian embassy complex on the condition that the UN would make an official request for the same. Using a 'ham radio' that was available to him at the time (only the UN had an INMARSAT phone), Nambiar contacted New Delhi to report the developments and sought official clearance for hosting Najibullah in his residential compound. However, protecting Najibullah and his family in Delhi was one thing, but giving him protection in the Indian embassy compound in Kabul, quite another. At 5.15 AM, India refused to grant Najibullah asylum in its embassy. Nambiar argues that 'he [Najibullah] was far safer in the UN compound ... [by sheltering him in the] Indian mission, we would have suddenly walked into all kinds of sub-continental rivalries, and problems would have then visited on us ... and there was no way in which we could reasonably expect security and safety for Najib in the Indian compound'.[14] New Delhi was worried about potential reprisals against the Indian community in Kabul if people found out that Najibullah was hiding in its embassy. There were few hundred Indian citizens including embassy staff in Afghanistan at that point.[15] In a conversation with Najibullah later that morning Nambiar communicated India's concerns about hosting him in the embassy. Najibullah allegedly understood Indian concerns, and, as per Nambiar, 'was quite adamant that this [his safety] was the responsibility of the United Nations'.[16]

J. N. Dixit, who was India's foreign secretary (1991–94), and who championed Najibullah in early 1980s, was concerned that offering him